Congress 41.4 per cent. Both polls show AAP emerging as a third force and likely to garner between 20 and 25 per cent of the votes. Most, however, will be drawn from the Congress's vote share, which is expected to drop drastically to around 25 per cent. The BJP's vote share will dip too, but not by much and is expected to stay above 45 per cent.

Pollsters, therefore, predict that the triangular contest may result in a decisive win for the BJP as the opposition vote will be divided in most constituencies. That's what gives Union minister Piyush Goyal, who has campaigned extensively on the ground for the BJP, the confidence to tell INDIA TODAY, "Mark my words, we will register a historic win in the state that will break all our previous records." He refuses to give a number though, saying things will be clearer only after the second phase of the campaign gets under way. The CVoter poll gives the BJP 131-139 out of a total of 182 seats, a significant increase from the 99 seats the party won in 2017. The Congress tally is expected to drop by half—from 77 seats in 2017 to 31-39 now. AAP is expected to make its debut with 7-15 seats. The BJP, however, is hoping to not just top its highest ever tally of 127 seats in 2002 but also best the record set by the Congress, which won 149 seats in 1985, under the leadership of Madhavsinh Solanki.

THE MODI BLITZKRIEG

Despite the encouraging predictions, Modi is not leaving anything to chance. He has been on a campaign blitzkrieg since the election was announced on November 3, holding rallies and roadshows almost every day across the length and breadth of Gujarat. For Modi, the Gujarat election is not just a battle for prestige, the outcome could also play a pivotal role in helping build momentum for the 2024 general election where he is hoping to secure a third term and become only the second prime minister after Jawaharlal Nehru to win back-to-back mandates thrice at the Centre. If BJP fortunes have in the past eight years seen a big uptick, it is because voters have regarded him as a strong and decisive leader who is pro-Hindutva but also pro-development and who has adopted a reforms-oriented approach towards governance. Gujarat was his laboratory before he moved to the Centre and the reason for his phenomenal and historic rise to the top. So, Modi not only needs to win Gujarat, but win it big.

The prime minister knows the imperatives and has been preparing for the Gujarat election long before others in his own party and in the rival ones got started. Having crafted a poll strategy along with Union home minister Amit Shah, he has been micro-managing it himself. He and his team identified five major issues that could mar the BJP's prospects, according to insiders. Topmost on the list was anti-incumbency and the undercurrent of resentment growing among some sections in recent years. The second was price

MODI'S 10-POINT GAME PLAN TO WIN GUJARAT

FROM A COMPLETE OVERHAUL OF THE GUJARAT CABINET WELL AHEAD OF THE POLLS ELECTION TO MICRO-MANAGING THE CAMPAIGN IN THE PAST FEW MONTHS, THE PM IS PERSONALLY OVERSEEING EVERY ASPECT OF THE POLLS

1. POLITICAL REVAMP

Seen as a passive leader, then CM **Vijay Rupani** along with his entire cabinet was sacked overnight in Sept. 2021. After the poor show in 2017 and resentment among Patels, the BJP wanted to fight the 2022 polls with a Patidar face





2. DEFANG CONGRESS

The BJP has fielded 17 Congress turncoats. The loss of tall community leaders—Kunvarji Bavaliya (Koli), **Hardik Patel** (Patidar), Jawahar Chavda and Alpesh Thakor (OBC)—has left the Grand Old Party shaken

AAP IS LIKELY TO CUT MORE INTO THE CONGRESS VOTE SHARE THAN BJP'S IN THIS UNPRECEDENTED TRIANGULAR CONTEST